

PHOTO BY **BANDEEP SINGH**

NIRMALA SITHARAMAN

UNION MINISTER, FINANCE AND CORPORATE AFFAIRS

Taking challenges head on, Nirmala Sitharaman—the country's longest serving finance minister—has managed to successfully navigate the economy through several turbulent periods like the Covid-19 pandemic, the US tariff headwind, and now the West Asia war that has led to a crude oil shock. Over the past one year, her policies have helped boost economic growth to 7.8% in FY26 while maintaining fiscal prudence in the face of rising fuel and fertiliser prices. She has also ushered in several reforms, including GST 2.0 and the new Income Tax Act.



PADMAJA RUPAREL

CO-FOUNDER, INDIAN ANGEL NETWORK

Padmaja Ruparel has been a driving force in India's start-up and angel-investing ecosystem for more than two decades. As Co-Founder and Senior Managing Partner of IAN Alpha Fund, she is now sharpening its focus on deeptech, backing founders in areas such as AI, semiconductors, spacetech, biotech, and advanced engineering. With a $100-million fund and IAN's deeptech investments reaching nearly ₹625 crore, her focus is on providing patient capital, mentorship, and market access to move breakthrough technologies from lab to market.

PHOTO BY **HARDIK CHHABRA**

NITA AMBANI

FOUNDER & CHAIRPERSON, RELIANCE FOUNDATION

There are many hats Nita Ambani wears and among them are being an educationist, philanthropist, a patron of the arts and sports, plus championing the cause of women's and children's rights. As Founder & Chairperson, Reliance Foundation, her task is to empower millions of Indians with both resources and opportunities. Just to elaborate, the entity focuses on rural transformation, health, disaster management, art, environmental and animal welfare, education, and sports for development.

